

currently hold more than 70 per cent share in the overall wearables category,” explains Vikas Sharma, Senior Market Analyst at IDC India. While boAt and Noise lead the pack, smaller India-based vendors are further fuelling growth in India’s wearables market.

It is on the back of these offerings coupled with the contribution of international players, including Chinese brands, that India is poised to become one of the largest markets for wearables in 2023, per IDC estimates. India will account for 130-135 million units of the estimated 504.1 million units that are expected to be shipped by 2023-end. Interestingly, out of the total of 492 million units sold in 2022, around 100 million were sold in India, placing it behind China and the US. But experts say that India has already surpassed the two countries this year on the back of low-cost yet feature-rich devices from local vendors.

GETTING IT RIGHT

When Varun Gupta started Boulton Audio in 2017, he was selling anywhere between a few hundred units of wireless audio devices to a thousand units, every month. But today, Boulton sells anywhere between 500,000 to 800,000 units a month. “In a good month, we’re able to sell over a million units when there’s an event period, or there’s a big sale event,” says the Co-founder and CEO of the company.

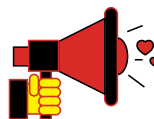
For him, it all started with his previous start-up, Brand Hawkers, an e-commerce consulting firm that was helping brands transition from offline to online sales. Of the 70 brands he worked with, around 15 were in the audio category. “On the demand side, I was very connected in terms of the product line based on emotion—what was working, what was not. When you work closely in any category, you start identifying the gaps. I took these gaps to my clients, but they were not so interested in fixing them. They said, you guys just sell the goods and don’t worry about how we [could] make them better, and how [to] price them, what colours, etc.”

Then from 2016 to 2017, Gupta started spending a lot of time in China, in the production facilities and research labs to understand how the product is made. His background in computer science and engineering helped him decode the engineering behind the product. Further, being a musician and a marketer helped him fix the demand side of it. When he launched Boulton Audio with his brother Tarun Gupta (Co-founder) they decided to launch with Myntra exclusively. “We had an 18-month contract with Myntra, and never had to worry about de-

THE EVOLUTION



Having started with limited funding, most home-grown brands initially imported products from China



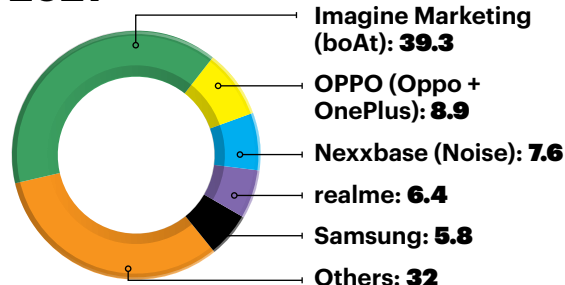
Indian brands like boAt and Noise quickly gained market share over their unbranded and Chinese counterparts by offering affordable, customised products as per the Indian audience’s preferences

THE GAME OF GADGETS

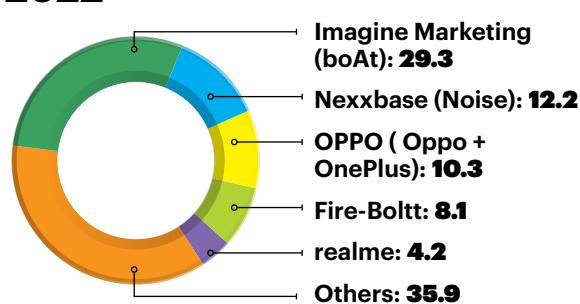
▶ INDIAN PLAYERS OCCUPY THE TOP 4 SPOTS IN THE WEARABLES SEGMENT

▶ THEIR COMBINED MARKET SHARE WAS NEARLY 60 PER CENT IN H1CY23

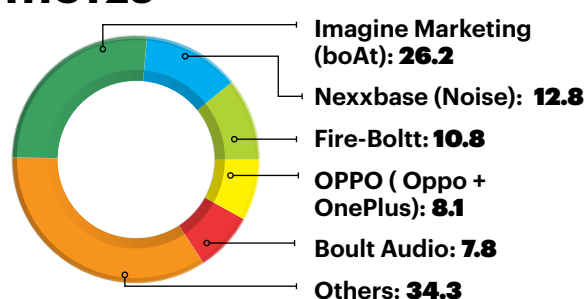
2021



2022



H1CY23



(Share of firms in wearable devices segment in India)

SOURCE IDC INDIA MONTHLY WEARABLE DEVICES TRACKER, AUGUST 2023